WEEK 11 · LECTURE L3 OF 3 · UNIT IV

Writing the Board Memo

Structure, tone, evidence and asks: the genre of CHRO communication, and the final presentation format.

Part 1 Structure, tone, evidence, asks

Part 2 Strong and weak memos compared

Part 3 Final presentation format: 12 minutes per pod

Read Sample Board Memos, strong and weak, annotated

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PART 1 · THE GENRE

A Board reads the first paragraph and decides whether to read on

Part	What it does
The ask	First paragraph: the decision, the money and the date
Three reasons	Each with one dataset figure, stated at full scale (Headcount_Fullscale_Est)
Risks and counter metric	What could go wrong, and the measure that would show it
Commitments	What HR will report, and when the Board can stop the program

MINTO'S PYRAMID Lead with the answer, then support it.

PART 2 · STRONG AND WEAK

What separates them

Weak memo	Strong memo
Opens with background	Opens with the ask, amount and date
Sample figures ("222 store associates")	Full-scale figures ("1,776 store associates")
"Gap of 34.6%"	"Gap of 34.6 percentage points"
Many asks, none prioritized	One ask the Board cannot refuse without explanation
No way to stop	A stop rule and a review date

PART 3 · FINAL PRESENTATIONS

12 minutes per pod: 10 to present, 2 for questions

Cover the whole case

Diagnosis, architecture, rollout, audit, story, and future-of-work strategy.

One thread

Show how each round's decision followed from the last.

Defend under questions

Expect to be asked which figure you would check twice.

WHEN Week 12, L1 and L2. Peer voting at the end on the most coherent and the most feasible plan.

Going deeper: the theory underneath persuasive writing

The next slides set out Minto's pyramid and SCQA, Grice's maxims, Toulmin's argument model, and Cialdini on persuasion: what each claims, how it works, where it breaks, and what it means at GreenLeaf.

THEORY IN DEPTH · MINTO (1987)

The pyramid principle and SCQA

THE CORE IDEA

Put the governing idea at the top, then group supporting reasons beneath it.

HOW IT WORKS

SCQA: Situation, Complication, Question, Answer; for a Board, move the Answer to the top.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Rigid structure can feel abrupt where readers expect context first.

AT GREENLEAF Your first paragraph is the top of the pyramid: the ask, the amount, the date.

THEORY IN DEPTH · GRICE (1975)

Four maxims of clear communication

THE CORE IDEA

Cooperative communication follows four maxims.

HOW IT WORKS

Quantity (as much as needed, no more), Quality (true, with evidence), Relation (relevant), Manner (clear and orderly).

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Real communication often breaks maxims on purpose, for politeness or effect.

AT GREENLEAF Cutting to 1,500 words is the maxim of quantity. Every sentence must earn its place.

THEORY IN DEPTH · TOULMIN (1958)

An argument has six parts

THE CORE IDEA

Claim, data, warrant, backing, qualifier and rebuttal.

HOW IT WORKS

The warrant explains why the data support the claim; the qualifier and rebuttal show honest limits.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Designed for analyzing arguments, so it can feel heavy for short writing.

AT GREENLEAF Each of your three reasons needs a warrant: why does this figure justify the ask?

THEORY IN DEPTH · CIALDINI (1984)

Six principles of influence, and their ethics

THE CORE IDEA

Reciprocity, commitment, social proof, authority, liking and scarcity.

HOW IT WORKS

People follow these shortcuts, especially under time pressure.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

The same principles can manipulate; use them only with true claims.

AT GREENLEAF

Social proof (peer retailers) persuades a Board, but only if the comparison is real and fair.

TAKEAWAYS

Three things to carry out of this lecture

1

Lead with the ask, the amount and the date.

2

Use full-scale figures and percentage points.

3

Give the Board a stop rule and a review date.

NEXT Week 12: final presentations and synthesis.